

“Dancing Machaut’s *Chansons baladées*: Unfixed Forms and Mensural Missteps”

The author introduces considerations of dance steps as a heuristic tool for the analysis of rhythmic subtleties of Machaut’s virelais, justified by the fact that Machaut himself insisted on several occasions that virelais are properly termed “danced songs” (*chansons baladées*). The results usefully expand studies of this period already underway regarding analysis of hypermeter (the medieval analogue is *modus*) as a factor important for cadential emphasis, performance agogics, phrase definition, etc. In particular, I find the long discussion of V38/32 “De tout sui” (pp. 32–41 and 50) excellent and quite convincing.

Sprinkled throughout, I also appreciated the excellent comments linking musical aspects to the poetry being set: p. 26 top; p. 28 (two instances); p. 40 n. 63; p. 43 top. The example of p. 14 middle (*clos* as metrically *ouvert*) is also very interesting in this regard.

Sometimes very careful regard for the very clear setting of musical notes to text syllables (clearest in MS Vg) works against the analysis that the author argues for. For example, “J’aim sans penser” (V14, Ex. 9, discussed pp. 16–18 and p. 19, end of n. 33). The very clear overlay of musical notes to text syllables in MS Vg (325v), mm. 8 and 12 of the example, shows an unequivocal setting as in Ludwig, with the syllable “-re” shifted one eighth later in each instance, and thus there is no overt shift of meter. When “Ludwig and Schrade beam mm. 8 and 12 as continued iambs,” they are following the very clear overlay of notes in Vg (and this seems to be the intent in the other MSS as well).

Line lengths and declamation patterns.

The author cites work on this subject, but does not really consider it much in the article. In some cases consideration of this issue would affect the analysis. For example:

Ex. 12 V5. in m. 5, the declamation of “dame” would be “da-ME” because that is where the syllables fall in the typical pattern for a 6-syllable line, which is ♩–♩–♩–.

Ex. 19. V32/29 and V27/24: both are 7-syll. lines, normally declaimed in alternating fashion, –♩–♩–♩–, which is of interest in both cases.

p. 47 top: again, the V27/24 version of 7-syll. declamation is at odds with the norm (mm. 1, 5, 11, 15, 17, 27 as noted), but V32/29 does not really follow “the same logic,” because there the 7-syll. lines are declaimed as normal.

This makes me think that information on line length (maybe a vertical stroke at line ends) and perhaps also syllable count should be included in the examples, since this aspect is obviously important to the poet and to the musical setting of the poetry, and it goes hand-in-hand with considerations of dance rhythm.

Some general matters of editing.

(1) numbering of virelais. Unfortunately, the two principal editions of Machaut (Ludwig 1926 and Schrade 1956) diverge beginning with V23 because Ludwig counted virelai texts not set to music that are taken into music sections of the MSS and Schrade did not. This could be handled by giving both numbers as relevant. An error slips in because of this issue on p. 22 n.40: the V27 referenced there is the V24 discussed on pp. 21ff. One could just write V27/24 to cover the two numberings; see also p. 32 n. 53.

(2) references to several virelais. p. 21 *et passim*: to me “Vv” implies “verses”; I have never seen anyone abbreviate “virelais” this manner. To me “V4, 27, and 36” is perfectly clear as

it stands (though better “V4, 27/24, and 36/30” for reasons just stated above in comment (1). Or else spell the plural “virelais 4, 27/24, and 36/30.”

Small details.

- p. 6 n. 10. Earp does not say “motet style”; rather “rhythmic innovations that had earlier been applied to the motet.”
- p. 7 n. 14. Translation is McGee’s; be sure that the reference reflects this, e.g., read: ...and descent” (trans. McGee 1989, 506).
- p. 8 n. 15. Give reference for Machaut calling virelai “danced songs.”
- pp. 9–10 Exx. 4 and 5: *de-mai-ne_a* (with elision), so the three eighths *agf* all set one syllable. Why does “(*fin*)” appear at the end of these two exx.? Also, plicas are given here as regular eighths, but the plica is given as a small note in Ex. 9, m. 6.
- p. 12 Ex. 7: need begin repeat bar at m. 11.5; and enter second text for the repeated music? Same for Ex. 8.
- p. 16 Ex. 9: needs separate stem for the eighth-note “-re” in m. 3.
- p. 18 n. 33. I find “pitch accent” example of V1 (Maw 2002, 72) weak. Perfect minor not supported by the poetic declamation. V18 example, however, is valid. Last sentence (already mentioned above in these comments) on text underlay of V14 in MSS is misleading: Vg very clear as usual; in others the intent is fairly clear.
- p. 26 n. 45. word division, read: “meinténir et”
- p. 29 and p. 31 Ex. 13 title of V20 is “Se d’amer me repentoie.”
- p. 32 n. 53. “essentially omitting my breve 23” – I do not understand this, nothing is omitted in Ludwig’s edition.
- p. 33 top: “this motive”—too vague. Some have called it “CBCA” for short, but one would need to say that it may be transposed; or give it as a musical example without clef, maybe on one line of a staff.
- p. 35 2nd para. “If this first phrase...” need to add “in Example 15,” or “in V38/32,” since Ex. 14 just mentioned is a different piece.
- p. 38 bottom “oxytonic rhymes -*smay* (m. 11) and -*vray* (m. 27)” better “oxytonic rhymes on -*ay* (mm. 11 and 27)”
- p. 38 n. 61. The “cadential retardation” in *Garrit/In nova* is a passage in perfect modus at the end of all six taleae, thus not just the end of the motet. Also, this not discussed in such terms by Desmond at that point in her book.
- p. 54 Moll 1998: the author is: Moll, Kevin N.
same page: Mullally 1998: typo in title, “Johannes”